

The searing rise of Auqib Nabi

With the medium pacer at the **peak of his powers** after a stellar campaign this Ranji Trophy season, the time appears ripe for the selectors to give him a chance in the unyielding cauldron of international cricket.

Anish Pathiyil

anish.p@thehindu.co.in

Can you swing the ball both ways? Can you pick a bucket-load of wickets through the season? Can you reproduce that wicket-taking ability even on docile tracks? Can you lead the bowling attack through the crunch knockout rounds? There is no question that Auqib Nabi has not answered in the affirmative to all these questions this season. The 29-year-old led the way for Jammu and Kashmir as the side wrote its name into the Ranji Trophy roll of champions for the first time in its history. Sixty wickets in 10 matches at an average of just 12.56 — Nabi's contributions have fuelled conversations about a national team call-up. And rightly so.

It hasn't been a one-season-wonder performance. Nabi picked 44 wickets in eight matches in the previous edition of the tournament to finish joint-second in the wicket-taking charts. J&K missed out on a place in the semifinal by a solitary run that year. Across the last two editions, he has claimed 13 five-wicket hauls, showing his propensity to run through opposition batting orders with utter disdain.

Nabi's rise to the top has come through an unfancied route, playing tennis-ball cricket well into his teens in Baramulla before making the switch to professional cricket. After his senior red-ball debut in 2019/20, Nabi was in and out of the J&K team until a couple of years ago, when he found an extra gear in his bowling. Speaking to *Sportstar*, Nabi explained that he struggled

to get a grip on his swing, often losing the ability to move the ball one way while trying to pursue the other. His control over his craft has come after years of grafting away on the practice pitch.

With the ability to move the ball both ways, Nabi was always going to be a menace to batters in the domestic circuit with the new red cherry in hand. But the real differentiator has been his ability to hit the right lengths with the old ball too, denying batters the chance to tilt the game back in their favour. In the Ranji Trophy final in Hubballi, it was this knack for holding a nagging length that helped Nabi remove Karun Nair and R. Smaran — arguably Karnataka's two best batters this season — without troubling the scorers. The pair of wickets with a 17-over-old ball proved to be the game-changing phase, putting the lesser-fancied J&K in the driver's seat against the eight-time champion.

The Jammu and Kashmir Cricket Association has been a key facilitator in Nabi and the team's exponential growth over the last couple of